

## License plate readers draw attention of Oklahoma lawmakers

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ARDMORE, Okla. (KTEN) — Automated license plate readers (ALPR) are being utilized by some law enforcement agencies throughout Oklahoma. A state representative has completed a legislative study looking into all of the technology's uses.

State [Rep. Tom Gann](#) (R-District 8) conducted the [study](#) because of his concern that installation of the crime-fighting cameras is not authorized by law.

"If anybody was willing to even take a cursory look of [Title 47 O.S. § 7-606.1 \(OSCN 2024\)](#), they would have easily been able to discern that any data collection on license plate readers outside of the Compulsory Insurance Law was unlawful," Gann explained. "There's some old axioms that say whatever the law allows, it encourages."

Gann said some law enforcement agencies throughout Oklahoma already have the license plate readers in place, including Tulsa, Claremore and Ardmore.

"We started doing a bunch of research into the different systems and programs. We also educated our city administration, our city council," Ardmore Police Captain Claude Henry said. "They were concerned, at first, about any invasion of privacies, and once we were able to explain how the system works and how the officers would only be able to engage in the database for law enforcement purposes only, they were assured enough to make that decision to invest in it."

Ardmore police began using the license plate readers this summer.

Henry said they've been used to help solve murders and to locate missing people or stolen vehicles, among other investigations.

"There's a database that collects this data that the LPRs capture; however, the only way that it's searchable is whenever an officer is using it for investigative purposes," Henry added. "They have to put a case number in, or they have to put a justification — which is the same for the database system the state operates under currently that houses license plate information."

For Rep. Gann, the hope is to modify law to address this new technology.

"We have to put safeguards around the data, protect people's privacy — if that's at all possible — and let law enforcement do their job to catch the bad guys and not jeopardize a conviction," Gann said.

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